

SPIRITUAL DISSONANCE

Understanding the tension of new faith - and standing firm when faith is tested

A NEW IDENTITY. AN OLD SET OF PATTERNS.

A person can truly come to Christ while still carrying old habits, fears, assumptions, desires, relationships and ways of thinking. Scripture describes Christian growth as an ongoing renewal of the mind and a putting off of the old self while putting on the new (Romans 12:2; Ephesians 4:22-24).

What does that dissonance feel like?

IDENTITY	"I belong to Christ" - while emotions still say, "I am the person I used to be."
TEMPTATION	Old desires can become more noticeable because the believer now recognizes them as contrary to God's will.
GUILT	A new sensitivity to sin can feel like regression even when it may reflect growing spiritual awareness.
DOUBT	Questions such as "Was my conversion real?" or "Did God really forgive me?" can become especially unsettling.
RELATIONSHIPS	Old social patterns may conflict with new convictions, creating pressure to return to what once felt normal.

Conversion is decisive; sanctification is progressive.

The tension itself is not proof that faith has failed. Galatians 5:16-17 describes a real conflict between the flesh and the Spirit. The Christian life includes learning to bring thought, desire and behavior increasingly under the truth of Christ.

"Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you."

James 4:7 - NIV

HOW SCRIPTURE DESCRIBES THE ATTACK

The Bible takes spiritual opposition seriously, but it emphasizes alertness, truth, resistance and dependence on God - not fear.

1 QUESTION GOD'S WORD	Genesis 3:1-5 The serpent begins by challenging what God actually said and by distorting God's character. A new believer may encounter doubts about whether God's promises, commands or forgiveness can really be trusted.
2 STEAL OR CHOKE THE WORD	Matthew 13:19 Jesus says the evil one seeks to snatch away the word that has been heard. Confusion, distraction and spiritual shallowness can keep truth from becoming deeply rooted.
3 TEMPT - THEN ACCUSE	Matthew 4:3; Revelation 12:10 Scripture calls Satan both tempter and accuser. The pattern can look like: "This sin doesn't matter" followed by "After that sin, how could you belong to God?"
4 USE SUFFERING TO PRODUCE DISTRUST	Job 1-2 Job shows an attempt to turn suffering into an argument against faithful trust: does someone love God only when life is going well?
5 INTIMIDATE & DISCOURAGE	1 Peter 5:8-9 Peter pictures the devil as a roaring lion, yet his command is not panic: resist him and stand firm in the faith.
6 DISTORT TRUTH	Matthew 4:1-11; 2 Corinthians 11:3 In Jesus' temptation, Scripture itself is quoted manipulatively. Not every spiritual-sounding idea is therefore a faithful use of God's Word.
"Be alert and of sober mind. Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion..." 1 Peter 5:8 - NIV	

HOW DOES A NEW BELIEVER RESPOND?

Scripture repeatedly moves the believer away from obsession with the enemy and toward active faithfulness to Christ.

TRUTH	Know and return to God's Word. Matthew 4:4; Ephesians 6:17
PRAYER	Watch and pray rather than relying on willpower alone. Matthew 26:41; Ephesians 6:18
RESISTANCE	Submit to God and actively resist temptation. James 4:7
CONFESSION	Bring sin into the light rather than hiding in shame. 1 John 1:9
COMMUNITY	Remain connected to believers who can encourage and correct. Hebrews 10:24-25
FAITH	Stand firm in what God has said, even when feelings lag behind. 1 Peter 5:9; Ephesians 6:16

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins..."

1 John 1:9 - NIV

CONVICTION vs. CONDEMNATION

Conviction: "This is sin. Bring it to God, turn from it, and walk forward."

Condemnation: "You sinned. Therefore God cannot want you anymore, so hide and give up."

Romans 8:1 answers the second message: for those who are in Christ Jesus, there is no condemnation. The gospel does not make sin insignificant; it makes repentance possible without hopelessness.

THE BIG IDEA

A new believer's experience may still be telling them who they *were*, while Scripture is teaching them who they *are in Christ*.

**Do not make the central question: "Was that Satan?"
Make the central question: "What would faithfulness to Christ look like here?"**

Scripture reading: Romans 12:2 • Galatians 5:16-17 • Ephesians 4:22-24 • Matthew 13:19 • Matthew 4:1-11 • Job 1-2 • 1 Peter 5:8-9 • 2 Corinthians 11:3 • James 4:7 • 1 John 1:9 • Romans 8:1 • Ephesians 6:10-18

Short Scripture quotations are from the NIV. Scripture references are included for further reading. NASB may be used as an alternate translation for study.